CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

HR MANAGER IN THE AI ERA

Every company eventually has a people problem it can't Google its way out of.

★ TL;DR — ~$75K median at the manager rung, but the ramp is long: 2–4 years of HR experience, credentials, and licensing steps. The catch: you're the referee in every conflict, including the ones nobody thanks you for. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

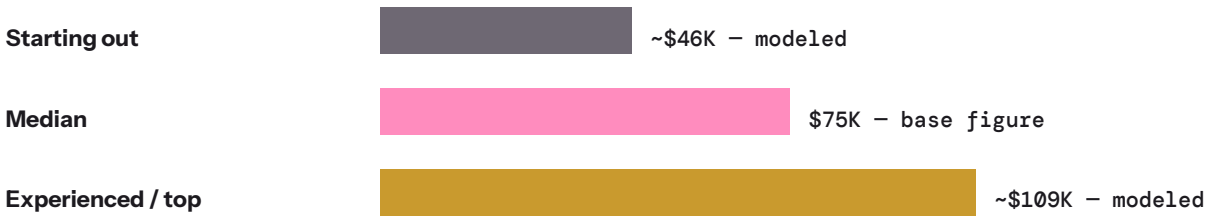
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK MEDIUM · STATE LICENSE

- HR managers get hired when a company grows big enough for people problems to get expensive.
- The role mixes law, psychology, and operations — hard to automate, hard to fake.
- AI handles the paperwork layer, which pushes the job toward judgment calls.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for HR Manager is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A HR MANAGER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Run hiring, onboarding, and offboarding processes
- ✓ Handle employee relations: conflicts, complaints, investigations

- ✓ Administer pay, benefits, and performance cycles
- ✓ Keep the company compliant with employment law and policy

Think: the referee, medic, and rulebook of a workplace — respected when fair, blamed by whoever lost.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI drafts policies, screens resumes, answers routine employee questions, and schedules everything. The administrative half of HR is shrinking fast.	Investigating a harassment claim, firing someone with dignity, or telling a founder their favorite manager is the problem — judgment and courage don't automate.

⚠ **This is a 2–4 year climb, not a pivot: manager titles go to people who've done the coordinator and generalist years. And you'll carry bad news weekly.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ A seat inside how the company actually runs ✓ Work that is different every single week ✓ Skills every sizable company needs	✗ Management to staff, staff to management — fully trusted by neither ✗ Confidential stress you can't take home and share ✗ Credit flows elsewhere; blame finds you

Good fit? You're fair under pressure, discreet by default, and can say hard things kindly.
Bad fit? You need to be liked by everyone, or conflict makes you avoidant.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — HR LADDER	DOOR B — SMALL-COMPANY FIRST HR
Climb: coordinator, generalist, then manager. Each rung adds a domain — recruiting, benefits, employee relations — until you can run the whole function for a smaller company.	Join a growing small company as its first real HR hire. You'll build everything from scratch — faster scope, thinner mentorship, and you'll learn by necessity.

Smart move: Get fluent in employment-law basics early — the HR person who prevents one lawsuit pays for their salary for years, and everyone knows it.
Where you land after: HR director, head of people, or HR consultant to small companies.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
ENTER THE	COVER THE	CREDENTIAL UP	MEET THE	OWN A	RUN THE

STEP 1 — Enter the function

PAID · YEAR 1

- Land an HR coordinator or assistant role — exposure beats theory.
- Volunteer for every process: onboarding, files, payroll support.

STEP 2 — Cover the core domains

YEARS 1-2

- Rotate through recruiting, benefits, and employee relations tasks.
- Learn your company's policies and where they came from.

STEP 3 — Credential up

EXAM FEES · YEARS 1-3

- Earn a recognized HR certification as your experience qualifies you.
- Study employment law alongside — it's the highest-value knowledge in the field.

STEP 4 — Meet the licensing requirements

STATE FEES · YEARS 2-3

- Some HR roles and jurisdictions require specific licenses or registered credentials — complete your state's licensing steps for your track.
- Keep registrations and continuing education current.

STEP 5 — Own a hard domain

YEARS 2-3

- Become the go-to for investigations or employee relations.
- Track your outcomes — discretion makes wins invisible unless you document impact.

STEP 6 — Run the function

WORKING · YEARS 3-4

- Step into the manager seat at your company or a smaller one.
- Own the calendar: reviews, open enrollment, audits, planning.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: read five HR manager job posts and list the experience and credentials they demand.
- □ Days 1–30: applications out for coordinator roles; employment-law basics study started.
- □ Days 31–60: in an HR seat or interviewing; learn your employer's handbook cover to cover.
- □ Days 61–90: own one small process end to end and make it visibly better.

 Day 90: you're in the pipeline with real HR exposure — the climb is measured in years, but it has started.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **FAIR. CALM. DOCUMENTED.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.